DANIELLE S. NAGLE

"ENGINEERING MARVEL": TOWARDS RESISTING THE AFFECTIVE POLITICS OF ERIE CANAL HERITAGE

Abstract

The Erie Canal is widely regarded as an engineering marvel; it is a symbol of American ingenuity, progress, and power, and it helped establish the U.S. global empire. In light of the 2025 canal bicentennial, however, there is a need for more critically conscious truth–telling regarding the lesser-known and more complicated aspects of Erie Canal heritage. Most notably, this includes broken treaties with the Six Nations of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy and the illegal theft of lands from Haudenosaunee peoples by New York State as facilitated by the Doctrine of Christian Discovery. However, inaction among settlers complicit in these ongoing struggles cannot be addressed solely through intellectual means; it requires critical affective engagements with dominant Erie Canal heritage discourses. I analyze the affective politics of Erie Canal heritage in the current planning efforts of the Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor and New York State Reimagine the Canals tourism and recreation marketing initiatives. I illustrate how the dominant narrative of the Erie Canal in heritage planning *neuropolitically* engineers feelings of marvel for the canal and perpetuates the discourse of discovery—the language of conquest, ownership, and profit foundational to the Doctrine of Christian Discovery. Consequently, many settlers remain unable to recognize the Erie Canal's ongoing violence; resisting the affective politics of dominant Erie Canal heritage marketing in support of Haudenosaunee sovereignty, therefore, requires cultivating deeper embodied awareness to more holistically address complexities of (in)justice in everyday contestations over lands and bodies.

Keywords: *Erie Canal, Doctrine of Christian Discovery, heritage tourism, affective resistance, neuropolitics*

DANIELLE S. NAGLE

"ENGINEERING MARVEL": TOWARDS RESISTING THE AFFECTIVE POLITICS OF ERIE CANAL HERITAGE

Introduction

The construction of the Erie Canal was made possible through the violation of numerous treaties established between the Six Nations of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy (Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, Seneca, and Tuscarora) and the U.S. Federal Government, including the Treaty of Fort Stanwix 1784, the Treaty of Fort Harmar 1789, and the Canandaigua Treaty of 1794, among others, treaties which are still legally binding under Article VI of the U.S. Constitution today. After a failed genocidal campaign ordered by future President George Washington, and carried out by Generals John Sullivan and James Clinton in 1779, additional fraudulent treaties were created by New York State (NYS), particularly in 1795, after the passage of the 1790 and 1793 Federal Indian Trade and Intercourse Acts, which prohibited the creation of treaties between states and sovereign Indigenous Nations, to facilitate the illegal accumulation of Haudenosaunee lands further.[1]

In 1823, two years before the construction of the Erie Canal was completed, the Supreme Court cemented the Doctrine of Christian Discovery (DoCD) in U.S. law in its *Johnson v. M'Intosh* decision. A set of Papal Bulls issued in the 15th century, the DoCD justified the theft of Indigenous lands by Christians, as well as the enslavement of non–Christian peoples. By codifying the DoCD into U.S. law, *Johnson v M'Intosh* cleared the way for the Erie Canal to rapidly drive westward expansion, enabling the continued theft of Indigenous lands throughout Turtle Island. Despite these violations, Haudenosaunee peoples within the Six Nations continue to resist colonial hegemony actively, upholding right relations with the land under the Great Law of Peace.[2] However, centuries of repeated failures by non–Indigenous (white) settlers to adhere to treaty law continue to create barriers to more profound healing.

This essay, therefore, considers the role of affective politics in Erie Canal heritage tourism and recreation marketing to understand better the dynamics between systemic harms and embodied responses that function to prevent critical engagements in addressing ongoing settler-colonial traumas. By contextualizing the DoCD within Erie Canal heritage planning and management, this research theoretically contributes to scholarly understandings of contesting and resisting systems of everyday affective power that control lands and bodies. As such, it examines the affective resonances of the DoCD in a specific place and opens up different possibilities for addressing the DoCD–that exist beyond colonial legal systems–while simultaneously retaining the potential to ripple into those systems and affect them over time. In this way, as embodied affective resistance is increasingly practiced, the DoCD is also slowly dismantled through changing discourses of place, such as those within Erie Canal heritage discourse. In turn, this can shift how people relate to place, opening more space for healing.

---

[1] Laurence M. Hauptman, *Conspiracy of Interests: Iroquois Dispossession and the Rise of New York State* (Syracuse University Press, 1999); Alyssa Mt. Pleasant, "After the Whirlwind: Maintaining a Haudenosaunee Place at Buffalo Creek, 1780–1825" (PhD diss., Cornell University, 2007). Onondaga Nation. "Treaties," accessed January 27, 2023. https://www.onondaganation.org/government/treaties/; Meredith Alberta Palmer, "Rendering Settler Sovereign Landscapes: Race and Property in the Empire State," *Environment and Planning D*: Society and Space 38, no. 5 (2020): 793–810.

[2] Mt. Pleasant, *After the Whirlwind*; Vanessa Watts, "Indigenous Place–Thought and Agency Amongst Humans and Non Humans (First Woman and Skywoman Go On a European World Tour*!),*" *Decolonization: Indigeneity, Education & Society* 2, no. 1 (2013): 20–34.

As a white settler scholar, I recognize my complicities in actively benefitting from these struggles, and acknowledge my responsibilities in working to address these harms; and move towards healing for both people and the Land, work filled with ambiguities and paradoxes: What will it take not to continue to turn my back to the complicated, challenging, and painful aspects of this heritage so traumas are no longer displaced onto future generations, and how will this process both open new possibilities while also re/producing harms? My sense of accountability stems more specifically from the place where I grew up, in what is today known as Bradford County, Pennsylvania. Through researching my ancestry, I learned I likely had ancestors who settled there in the late 1700s; in connecting my ancestry with the Erie Canal, I came across a map of the Sullivan–Clinton Genocide, which passed along the Susquehanna River near where I grew up. I was never taught about this historically violent event, but I did pass one particular roadside marker relatively often. Never knowing what it truly represented, its presence registered only subconsciously, not returning to the surface until I began researching and teaching about the Erie Canal. Thus, I root my ongoing complicities with the Erie Canal in the lands violently stolen and settled by my ancestors.

I also recognize the Erie Canal as Land, as a living entity with personhood and rights, and not a resource to be used and exploited solely for human benefit.[3] The fish, insects, birds, beavers, rusting cans, mink, algae, microplastics, strawberries, dandelions, honey locusts, poison ivy, soils, fossil fuels, stones, bacteria, and other beings for whom the Erie Canal is home similarly share these rights, and all deserve our most profound respect and gratitude. Significantly, it cannot be understated that the Erie Canal disrupted the sacred relationships Haudenosaunee peoples hold with these lands and waters.[4] Its construction fundamentally altered the flow of water for an entire geographic region, extending well beyond the political boundaries of today's New York State. As a white settler, I must therefore be mindful to acknowledge that my recognition of these lands as living entities should not erase traditional Haudenosaunee relationships with these places, but rather, serve as a reminder to be humble in ways my ancestors were not, as I seek to cultivate different relationships based in trust, consent, reciprocity, and respect today.[5]

The following two sections provide background on the academic literature on affective heritage and Erie Canal heritage. I then describe my methodological approach before discussing the results of my analysis. I frame the results around the notion of "engineering marvel", arguing that because the canal is often called an engineering marvel, Erie Canal heritage discourse is also an engineering project, one channeling effect rather than water. To conclude, I offer suggestions for moving towards resisting the affective politics of Erie Canal heritage, particularly in advance of the 2025 bicentennial.

Affective heritage landscapes

Contemporary approaches to landscape are rooted in historical relations, in which elites asserted control over the land by employing romanticized, linear visual aesthetic scenes. Consequently, land is situated as something ideologically abstract, distant, and empty (i.e.,

---

[3] Zoe Todd, "Fish, Kin and Hope: Tending to Water Violations in amiskwaciwâskahikan and Treaty Six Territory," *Afterall: A Journal of Art, Context and Enquiry* 43 (2017): 95–99. Watts, "Indigenous Place–Thought and Agency"

[4] Indigenous Values Initiative, *Sacred Waters –– Trauma of the Erie Canal*, produced by Indigenous Values Initiative, YouTube video, 103:54, April 12, 2021, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e4yystxtIoM.

[5] Vanessa Machado de Oliveira, *Hospicing Modernity: Facing Humanity's Wrongs and the Implications for Social Activism* (North Atlantic Books, 2021).

terra nullius), facilitating localized material transformations in the form of colonial projects of dispossession, resource extraction, and wealth accumulation.[6] Bluwstein identifies depoliticization, simplification, and representation as three central problems embedded within the colonial landscape aesthetics.[7] "Historically, landscape has been used as a disciplinary tool to facilitate the control of land and to naturalize colonial hegemonies."[8] Through these processes, landscape becomes a technology of nation–states that reinforces racialized relations of inequality.

The powerful imaginary of landscape thus has deeply embodied consequences.[9] Nationalized identities associated with landscape imaginaries become mythologized in ways that alienate certain bodies while privileging others.[10] Reinforced through storytelling, such political projects promote a homogenized, categorized, and universalized sense of place that denies complexity, plurality, and relationality and maintains colonial control over stolen Indigenous lands through discursive absences.[11] Yet, these are not strictly discursive or textual with material implications–they also create affective resonances.[12] Through storytelling, "landscape is a key element in creating a sense of place, becoming a key element in the commercial 'exploitation' of the geographical intangible (feelings, emotions, sensations, and experiences)."[13]

Ahmed's theorizations on affect illustrate that emotions act in the world, functioning as a form of capital to construct collective coherence.[14] Certain emotions arise in response to particular words, images, bodies, etc., and these are fortified through cultural conditioning. Importantly, absences do not simply disappear; they become repressed. As emotions do things, there is a "rippling effect" in which they "move sideways (through 'sticky' associations between signs, figures, and objects) as well as backward (repression always leaves its trace in the present—

---

[6] Jevgeniy Bluwstein, "Colonizing Landscapes/Landscaping Colonies: From a Global History of Landscapism to the Contemporary Landscape Approach in Nature Conservation," *Journal of Political Ecology* 28, no. 1 (2021): 904–927; Denis Cosgrove, "Prospect, Perspective and the Evolution of the Landscape Idea," *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers* 10, no. 1 (1985): 45–62; Don Mitchell, "Cultural Landscapes: Just Landscapes or Landscapes of Justice?" *Progress in Human Geography* 27, no. 6 (2003): 787–796; Kenneth R. Olwig, "Recovering the Substantive Nature of Landscape," *Annals of the American Association of Geographers* 86, no. 4 (1996): 630–653.

[7] Bluwstein, "Colonizing Landscapes/Landscaping Colonies."

[8] Tiffany Kaewen Dang, "Decolonizing Landscape," *Landscape Research* 46, no. 7 (2021): 1004

[9] Carolyn Finney, *Black Faces, White Spaces: Reimagining the Relationship of African Americans to the Great Outdoors* (The University of North Carolina Press, 2014); Dorceta E. Taylor, *The Rise of the American Conservation Movement: Power, Privilege, and Environmental Protection* (Duke University Press, 2016); John Wylie, *Landscape* (Routledge, 2007).

[10] Marco Antonsich, Michael Skey, Shanti Sumartojo, et al., "The Spaces and Politics of Affective Nationalism," *Environment and Planning C: Politics and Space* 38, no. 4 (2020): 579–598; Divya P. Tolia-Kelly, "Feeling and Being at the (Postcolonial) Museum: Presencing the Affective Politics of 'Race' and Culture," *Sociology 50*, no. 5 (2016a): 896–912; Divya P. Tolia–Kelly, "Race and Affect at the Museum: The Museum as a Theater of Pain," in *Heritage, Affect and Emotion: Politics, Practices and Infrastructures,* ed. Divya P. Tolia–Kelly, Emma Waterton, and Steve Watson (Routledge, 2016b).

[11] Arts, Bas, Marleen Buizer, Lummina Horlings, Verina Ingram, Cora Van Oosten, and Paul Opdam. "Landscape Approaches: A State-of-the-Art Review." *Annual Review of Environment and Resource*s 42, no. 1 (August 23, 2017): 439–63. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-environ-102016-060932; Bluwstein, "Colonizing Landscapes/Landscaping Colonies," 904–927; Katherine McKittrick, "On Plantations, Prisons, and a Black Sense of Place," *Social & Cultural Geography* 12, no. 8 (2011): 947–963.

[12] Sara Ahmed, "Affective Economies," *Social Text* 22, no. 2 (2004): 117–139; Antonsich et al., "The Spaces and Politics of Affective Nationalism;" Nigel Thrift, "Intensities of Feeling: Towards a Spatial Politics of Affect," *Geografiska Annaler* 86, no. 1 (2004): 57–78; Divya P. Tolia-Kelly, "Affect: An Ethnocentric Encounter? Exploring the 'Universalist' Imperative Emotional/Affectual Geographies," *Area 38*, no. 2 (2006): 213–217.

[13] Jordi de San Eugenio Vela, Joan Nogué, and Robert Govers, "Visual Landscape as a Key Element of Place Branding," *Journal of Place Management and Development 10*, no. 1 (2017): 34.

[14] Ahmed, "Affective Economies."

hence 'what sticks' is also bound up with the 'absent presence' of historicity.)"[15] In terms of nation–states, "affective nationalism is about attending to how feelings and emotions emerge through practices, objects, and materially heterogeneous assemblages which are imbricated with the nation."[16] Affective movements shape the nation. Therefore, nations are not fixed and static; they are always in motion and, thus, incomplete, continuously being made and remade, which leaves cracks for their unmaking as well.

Consequently, the nation must constantly work to maintain its identity and power. One instance of the affective strategies nations use is evident in marketing and branding storytelling strategies. For example, landscape branding is a form of place branding that utilizes landscapes as brands, commodifying an imaginary of place that ultimately materializes. The visual is central to these endeavors, serving a "carefully orchestrated construction of gazes, angles, representations, narratives, and interpretations characteristic of geographic space, which somehow hijack the spontaneous gaze to take it to a certain place. *Everything is perfectly premeditated*" (emphasis added).[17] For example, Hoksins discusses the engineered wilderness gaze that perpetuates a romanticized, ocular–centric view via scenic overlooks, functioning to promote a sense of superiority and depoliticize landscapes, affectively "freez[ing] us of a politics of the present and from an imperative to act."[18]

Another way nations work to maintain themselves effectively is through brandscapes. Brandscapes undergird an affective economy in which experiences and lifestyles are central to consumer society, and seek to elicit positive emotional responses, trust, and comfort in consumers to ensure continued consumptive engagement. The underlying assumption in marketing is that desires must be "activated" in consumers because they are purportedly unable to know what they truly desire.[19] Consequently, brandscapes constitute a form of neuropolitical control, as affective responses become unconsciously desired neurological elicitations within the brain and body. In considering the etymology of the term brand, which means "a mark made by a hot iron," both landscape branding and brandscapes draw into sharp relief how nations force themselves on both bodies and the land, with impacts that are unevenly felt and inherently racialized.[20]

The elicitation of positive affects and emotions through branding works to cover up such state–sanctioned psychological abuses. Further, feelings and affects are not always strong but can also manifest as ambivalence, numbness, disillusionment, and unease.[21] These responses can be understood as obscuring other repressed emotions, such as anger, fear, and despair, which may arise when state violence becomes visible.[22] In another sense, such affective patterns are reflective of the mobilities of trauma, and how trauma is structurally embedded in modern colonial systems as an integral component of the affective economy. Therefore, trauma is

---

[15] Ahmed, "Affective Economies," 120.

[16] Antonsich et al., "Spaces and Politics of Affective Nationalism," 2.

[17] de San Eugenio Vela et al., "Visual Landscape as a Key Element of Place Branding," 37.

[18] Gareth Hoskins, "Overlooking Affect? Vertigo as Geo–Sensitive Industrial Heritage at Malakoff Diggins, California," in *Heritage, Affect, and Emotion: Politics, Practices, and Infrastructures*, ed. Divya P. Tolia-Kelly, Emma Waterton, and Steve Watson (Routledge, 2017), 148.

[19] David Murakami Wood and Kirstie Ball, "Brandscapes of Control? Surveillance, Marketing and the Co–Construction of Subjectivity and Space in Neo–Liberal Capitalism," *Marketing Theory 13*, no. 1 (2013): 49.

[20] Ahmed, "Affective Economies;" Antonsich et al., "Spaces and Politics of Affective Nationalism;" Tolia-Kelly, "Feeling and Being at the (Postcolonial) Museum;" Harper 2023

[21] Antonsich et al., "Spaces and Politics of Affective Nationalism."

[22] Ahmed, "Affective Economies."

constituted through *relations*, becoming unequally layered and compounded together over time.[23] "As traumatic events leave traces of past horrors upon the landscape, places that have experienced trauma *feel* differently"(emphasis added).[24] Pain conceptualizes this in terms of geotrauma, or "the multiscalar, intersecting and mutual relations between trauma and place."[25] Significantly, trauma to the land cannot be separated from embodied traumas.[26]

The exposure of different racialized, gendered, classed, and abled bodies to these layered traumas can result in the formation of different political communities through the affective economies of emotions.[27] Communities "can continue to engender more violence in trauma's name, or they can aim to imagine futures beyond trauma's current historical iteration."[28] In the context of museums, Tolia–Kelly argues, "affective atmospheres accumulate through the ages, and thus it is necessary to conceptualize the depth of subjugation, denial, and violence experienced therein," experiences she situates as akin to "theaters of pain."[29] Micieli–Voutsinas suggests "affective heritage mobilizes embodied experiences in relation to memorial dogma to produce a kind of 'feeling truth' for visitors."[30] The affective economies of branding can reinforce feeling truths, forming an internalized "affective prison" that "begins to mark the boundaries of emotional range and becomes simply too inconvenient or uncomfortable to be without."[31] When the truths of heritage foster a sense of alienation rather than the expected wonder and awe, trauma may be "transmitted…through visceral registries" and experienced again in the present.[32]

Simultaneously, affective politics create space for resistance and the cultivation of new imagined possibilities beyond traumatic histories. "More than an analytical lens, affective nationalism is something that has to be unpacked to not only disclose how power and affect are closely imbricated, but also to resist and subvert the affective appeal associated with objects and manifestations of state violence,"[33] Hoskins suggests vertigo can be an embodied unsettling that brings us back to the ground where we can foster critical engagement with depoliticized heritages.[34] Both Pain and Tolia–Kelly encourage scholars to look to Black, Indigenous, and communities of color more broadly who continue to resist, survive, and thrive

---

[23] Kate Coddington and Jacque Micieli-Voutsinas, "On Trauma, Geography, and Mobility: Towards Geographies of Trauma," *Emotion, Space and Society* 24 (2017): 52–56; Rachel Pain, "Geotrauma: Violence, Place and Repossession," *Progress in Human Geography* 45, no. 5 (2021): 972–989.

[24] Coddington and Micieli-Voutsinas, "On Trauma, Geography, and Mobility," 5.

[25] Pain, "Geotrauma," 974.

[26] Bjørn Sletto, Magdalena Novoa, and Raksha Vasudevan, "'History Can't Be Written without Us in the Center': Colonial Trauma, the Cartographic Body, Decolonizing Methodologies in Urban Planning," *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space* 41, no. 1 (2023): 148–169.

[27] Ahmed, "Affective Economies."

[28] Coddington and Micieli-Voutsinas, "On Trauma, Geography, and Mobility," 15.

[29] Tolia-Kelly, "Feeling and Being at the (Postcolonial) Museum," 899 and 902; Tolia–Kelly, "Race and Affect at the Museum."

[30] Jacque Micieli–Voutsinas, "An Absent Presence: Affective Heritage at the National September 11th Memorial & Museum," *Emotion, Space and Society* 24 (2017): 2.

[31] Wood and Ball, "Brandscapes of Control?" 62.

[32] Coddington and Micieli–Voutsinas, "On Trauma, Geography, and Mobility," 11; Tolia-Kelly, "Feeling and Being at the (Postcolonial) Museum;" Tolia–Kelly, "Race and Affect at the Museum."

[33] Antonsich et al., "Spaces and Politics of Affective Nationalism," 4.

[34] Hoskins, "Overlooking Affect?"

in the face of state–sanctioned systems of trauma.[35] Alternative affective politics that can emerge when encountering heritage landscapes, therefore, create spaces for self–determination.[36]

It is this spirit of affective resistance I hope to encourage in relation to Erie Canal heritage. Beyond linear, ocular–centric views of landscape, Tsing reminds us "[l]andscapes…are gatherings of ways of being in the making," both human and more–than–human, and "even a small…moment of friction…has landscape–making effects."[37] Thus, finding ways to disrupt the dominant affective politics of Erie Canal heritage that has hypnotized so many into forgetting the violences entangled with the Erie Canal may help to open up other possible coordinations of coexistence. In the next section, I begin to unsettle the dominant narrative promoted within the Erie Canal heritage landscape.

Unsettling the Celebrated Erie Canal Heritage Landscape

In a recent study of nearly 50 Erie Canal heritage sites, Barry and Teron found dominant Erie Canal narratives promote a "nostalgic, imposed gaze underpinned by the powerful ideologies of place, race, and nationhood that sustain inequality." [38] The Erie Canal is commonly framed as an engineering marvel and an accomplishment initially deemed impossible by most, including President Thomas Jefferson. However, it was relentlessly pursued by New York State Governor DeWitt Clinton, who remained undeterred by references to his vision as nothing more than "Clinton's Ditch". It symbolized American exceptionalism, ingenuity, progress, and the making of New York as the "Empire State" and center of global capital, situating the canal as a key factor influencing the transportation revolution that enabled westward expansion through the supposed "wilderness" (*terra nullis*) in what is today considered the United States.

However, the lands upon which the Erie Canal was constructed were not a wilderness devoid of human presence; they were, and continue to be, home to Haudenosaunee peoples who have been stewards of the land here since time immemorial. The Sullivan–Clinton Genocide of 1779 tried to erase this reality; through military warfare across portions of Pennsylvania and throughout New York, George Washington sent Generals Sullivan and Clinton (father of DeWitt Clinton) on a mission to destroy Haudenosaunee settlements, agricultural fields, and harvests. While estimates suggest approximately half of Haudenosaunee peoples were killed as a result of the genocide and the harsh winter that followed, Sullivan and Clinton ultimately failed in their mission, and Haudenosaunee peoples survived and continue to maintain their cultural practices today.[39]

---

[35] Pain, "Geotrauma;" Tolia-Kelly, "Feeling and Being at the (Postcolonial) Museum." See also Eve Tuck, "Suspending Damage: A Letter to Communities," Harvard Educational Review 79, no. 3 (2009): 409–428.

[36] Tolia-Kelly, "Feeling and Being at the (Postcolonial) Museum."

[37] Anna Tsing, "The Buck, the Bull, and the Dream of the Stag: Some unexpected weeds of the Anthropocene." *Suomen Antropologi: Journal of the Finnish Anthropological Society 42*, no. 1 (2017): 7,14.

[38] Renée Barry and Lemir Teron, "Visualizing Heritage: A Critical Discourse Analysis of Place, Race, and Nationhood along the Erie Canal," *Local Environment 28*, no. 6 (2023): 1, https://doi.org/10.1080/13549839.2023.2173731.

[39] Barry and Teron, "Visualizing Heritage;" Rhiannon Koehler, "Hostile Nations: Quantifying the Destruction of the Sullivan–Clinton Genocide of 1779," *American Indian Quarterly* 42, no. 4 (2018): 427–453; Mt. Pleasant, "After the Whirlwind; Palmer, "Rendering Settler Sovereign Landscapes;" Andrea Lynn Smith and Nëhdöwes Randy A. John, "Monuments, Legitimization Ceremonies, and Haudenosaunee Rejection of Sullivan–Clinton Markers," *New York History* 101, no. 2 (2021): 343–365.

Nevertheless, initial surveys of these lands began as early as 1784, the same year the Treaty of Fort Stanwix was signed with the Haudenosaunee Confederacy.[40] After the passage of the Federal Indian Trade and Intercourse Acts of 1790 and 1793, which prohibited states from making treaties with sovereign Tribal Nations, the Haudenosaunee Confederacy again came together with the United States to establish the Canandaigua Treaty of 1794 in an assurance of peace and friendship between the Six Nations and the federal U.S. government. Federal laws would not stop DeWitt Clinton and other New York State officials, however. In 1795, New York State entered into fraudulent treaties, resulting in the loss of the vast majority of traditional Haudenosaunee homelands. Numerous additional treaties and violations occurred in subsequent decades, which facilitated the construction of the Erie Canal.[41] Initial construction began in Rome, New York, on July 4, 1817, and was completed on October 26, 1825, just two years after the *Supreme Court's Johnson v. M'Intosh* decision of 1823, which established the Doctrine of Christian Discovery in U.S. law. Of the groundbreaking, Bernstein notes, "A town with an imperial name was about to witness the birth of a project that would turn New York into an imperial state."[42]

However, the realities underlying the canal's construction have been mainly forgotten over the last 200 years.[43] By noting that recorded histories authorized by the nation often differ significantly from what actually happened, Erie Canal commemorations have further distorted public memory.[44] To celebrate the canal's opening in 1825, DeWitt Clinton rode a boat named the *Seneca Chief* on a ten–day journey from Buffalo to New York City. Directly following him was another boat, *Noah's Ark,* that held various animals, in addition to two young Seneca boys.[45] Clinton also brought along water from the Erie Canal, which he ceremoniously poured into the Atlantic Ocean in an overtly sexualized event known as the "Wedding of the Waters."[46]

Described as a "fairyland," centennial celebrations of the Erie Canal in the 1920s were no less discriminatory and, in fact, mirrored many of the original commemorative events.[47] For the centennial, the original route of DeWitt Clinton was reversed. Upon reaching Lake Erie in a boat named the *DeWitt Clinton*, Clinton's grandson, George, emptied water from the Atlantic Ocean into Lake Erie, mirroring the original "Wedding of the Waters," later giving a speech in which he expressed racist sentiments against the Haudenosaunee. American exceptionalism permeated celebratory events, including warship parades, fireworks displays, and speeches by state political and financial leaders. When a final flotilla of boats arrived from New York City during the fourth phase, "they were met by celebrants in 'authentic' colonial and Native American costumes."[48] DeWitt Clinton attained mythic status for his centrality to these

---

[40] Justin Nordstrom, "Public Memory and Popular Culture: The Erie Canal in the Imagination of the 1920s," *New York History* 80, no. 4 (1999): 423–454; Hauptman, *Conspiracy of Interests*; Mt. Pleasant, "After the Whirlwind."

[41] Hauptman, *Conspiracy of Interests*; Mt. Pleasant, "After the Whirlwind."

[42] Peter L. Bernstein, *Wedding of the Waters: The Erie Canal and the Making of a Great Nation* (W. W. Norton & Co., 2005), 199.

[43] Camden Burd, "A New, Historic Canal: The Making of an Erie Canal Heritage Landscape," *Journal of the Society for Industrial Archaeology* 42, no. 2 (2016): 23–34; Carol Sheriff, "'Not the True Centennial': The Politics of Erie Canal Celebrations, 1917–1926," *New York History* 99, nos. 3–4 (2018): 370–408.

[44] Michel-Rolph Trouillot, *Silencing the Past: Power and the Production of History* (Beacon Press, 2015).

[45] Barry and Teron, "Visualizing Heritage;" Sheriff, "'Not the True Centennial.'"

[46] Bernstein, *Wedding of the Waters* .

[47] Nordstrom, "Public Memory and Popular Culture;" Sheriff, "'Not the True Centennial.'"

[48] Nordstrom, "Public Memory and Popular Culture," 431.

commemorations.[49] Despite the canal's putrid conditions during this time, WWI had a strong influence, reinforcing the canal's national symbolism.[50]

The Sheriff has identified differences in the 1967 sesquicentennial and 2017 bicentennial commemorations of the Erie Canal.[51] The sesquicentennial was primarily focused in Rome, NY, with a four–day event centered around a reenactment of the original canal groundbreaking; the 2017 celebrations were less centralized, spanning 27 different events throughout the state, many of which were not initially associated with the canal's groundbreaking bicentennial. In some cases, a broader range of perspectives was incorporated, including discussions of environmental destruction and social harms. In contrast, the centennial celebration of the 1920s primarily focused on the accomplishments of engineers and political leaders, which not only espoused racist views and ignored the genocidal violence committed against the Haudenosaunee but also largely failed to acknowledge the laborers, children, and animals who often faced abuse and died during the canal's construction. Some localized exceptions did touch on these realities, exposing tensions with the state's narrative. Nevertheless, commemorations of Erie Canal heritage largely reflect a positive nationalistic view.

Sheriff also noted the 1926 centennial of the Erie Canal's opening included slightly more participation from women and Haudenosaunee peoples, albeit underscored by discrimination.[52] Still, we should be cautious about assuming the descriptions of and influences behind such participation, many of which are drawn from a state report documenting the events in which George Clinton is listed as the first author.[53] For instance, during this same era, with support from Syracuse University professor Alexander Flick, the New York State Department of Education was building markers commemorating the Sullivan–Clinton "Campaign". The central message, which attempted to turn genocide into celebration, was founded on the notion that "Sullivan–Clinton set the stage for the expansion of the Empire State."[54] However, as Smith and John note:

> This is a gross simplification, if not an outright lie. For one, [Haudenosaunee] attacks on frontier settlements after 1779 were even *more* devastating than before. In fact, to this day, historians debate whether the expedition achieved its wartime goals and are mixed in their assessment of its strategic consequences (*emphasis* original).[55]

Haudenosaunee peoples overwhelmingly rejected this commemorative effort, refusing to celebrate the traumatic and inaccurately narrated historical event; to be sure, they maintained vast amounts of their lands in the years following 1779. Moreover, although direct linkages cannot be conclusively proven, during the 1920s, the Haudenosaunee Nations were simultaneously challenging New York State through land rights legal actions, asserting their sovereignty over lands illegally stolen through treaty violations. Much like the centennial commemorations of the Erie Canal's opening, however, state promoters of dedication events

---

[49] Nordstrom, "Public Memory and Popular Culture."

[50] Sheriff, "'Not the True Centennial.'"

[51] Sheriff, "'Not the True Centennial.'"

[52] Sheriff, "'Not the True Centennial.'"

[53] New York (State) Erie Canal Centennial Commission and George Clinton, *The Erie Canal Centennial Celebration, 1926: The Final Report of the Erie Canal Centennial Commission Submitted to the Governor and the Legislature January, Nineteen Twenty–eight* (Albany: J.B. Lyon Company, Printers, 1928).

[54] Smith and John, "Monuments, Legitimization Ceremonies," 351.

[55] Smith and John, "Monuments, Legitimization Ceremonies," 351.

unveiling the Sullivan–Clinton markers continued to pursue an inclusive front, and ultimately did find a small number Haudenosaunee participants; although, the motivations behind this participation could include a variety of factors, such as monetary compensation, and should not necessarily be understood as condonement of the markers themselves.[56] To be sure, Haudenosaunee peoples have demonstrated a keen ability to survive and thrive despite colonial violence.[57]

"Heritage can twist historical accuracy for modern purposes."[58] The celebrated heritage narratives of the Erie Canal promoted by New York State today are the continuation of a centuries–long trend of erasures and misrepresentations. Against this complex historical backdrop, the state is now reimagining the canal as a burgeoning tourism industry and recreational way for the bicentennial. Amid fears that the Erie Canal has been largely forgotten in public memory and American consciousness, New York State seeks to cultivate an "easygoing" attitude and appreciation for the canal going forward.[59] Yet, this comes at stark contrast to the violent realities of the canal, raising questions around the bicentennial celebration of the canal's opening, which is set to take place at the World Canals Conference during September 2025 in Buffalo, and to what extent it may reflect past commemorative events.[60] What are the consequences of continued silence around the complex histories of the Erie Canal in heritage practices today? Whose comfort and ideas of safety are upheld through the maintenance of silence, and at whose expense?[61]

Such questions illustrate that the affective politics surrounding New York State's ongoing reimagining of the Erie Canal heritage landscape warrant deeper critical analysis. More specifically, my analysis engages with the following research questions:

1. What affective responses does New York State privilege in its reimagining of the Erie Canal heritage landscape?

2. What subjectivities are the state's engineering in relation to the Erie Canal, and how?

3. How might ongoing state initiatives be limiting our capacities to heal past and ongoing harms and collectively reckon with unjust histories, without erasing uneven complicities, so we may begin to imagine other possibilities for the Erie Canal landscape?

I contend it is precisely *because* the canal has largely been forgotten in public memory and consciousness that space is emerging for us to re/member what has too long been forced into silence and to actively resist the violent dominance of narratives promoted by New York State, so we do not spend another century failing to address the state–sanctioned harms associated with the Erie Canal.

Methodology

[56] Smith and John, "Monuments, Legitimization Ceremonies."

[57] Hauptman, *Conspiracy of Interests*; Koehler, "Hostile Nations;" Mt. Pleasant, "After the Whirlwind;" Smith and John, "Monuments, Legitimization Ceremonies."

[58] Burd, "A New, Historic Canal," 29.

[59] Burd, "A New, Historic Canal."

[60] New York State, *A3362* (February 2, 2023), https://www.nysenate.gov/legislation/bills/2023/A3362.

[61] Jenny Kidd and Joanne Sayner, "Intersections of Silence and Empathy in Heritage Practice," *International Journal of Heritage Studies* 25, no. 1 (2019): 1–4.

In 1995, New York State developed the Canal Recreationway Plan, envisioning the Erie Canal as a linear park, economic development engine, and international tourist destination, to implement the plan for the canal's bicentennial. To reinscribe the Erie Canal in the American consciousness, the 1995 plan "sought to launch 'the next chapter in the canal system's story' –a new vision of the canal system as a gathering place for leisure–time enjoyment, re–energizing adjacent communities and bringing new benefits and prosperity."[62] In 2017, Governor Cuomo implemented a $300 million initiative to reimagine the canal to complete this vision. Planning and marketing documents about the more recent Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor and Reimagine the Canals tourism and recreation–related initiatives, which build from the initial 1995 plan, form the focus of this analysis. [63]

The Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor (ECNHC) is a partnership between the National Park Service and the State of New York. Within the state, marketing of these initiatives is primarily handled by the New York State Canal Corporation–a subdivision of the New York Power Authority–and by the Empire State Development Corporation, Division of Marketing, Advertising, and Tourism, which administers the "I LOVE NY" campaign.[64] The prevalence of this campaign in marketing the Erie Canal highlights the significance of affective politics to my analysis.

To analyze the affective politics of Erie Canal heritage discourses in the ongoing ECNHC and Reimagine the Canals initiatives, I draw from Lähdesmäki's research on the politics of affect in EU heritage policy materials: "affect should be taken seriously because it enables an exercise of power; affect can be an object of engineering deployed politically for political ends."[65] Thus, affect is a key technology that facilitates the state's engineering of subjectivities.[66] In considering "the capacities of affect to activate and become political."[67] I also seek to remain attentive to how affective movements are inherently racialized.[68]

Following Lähdesmäki, I examine the affective textual and narrative "tropes" repeated throughout the data.[69] This allows me to more clearly examine the explanatory factors the state uses to justify its affective politics in Erie Canal heritage marketing. The materials I analyze are approached with the understanding that they have the potential to promote particular ideological and political stances and reinforce specific (unequal) power dynamics. I consider these stances and dynamics systemically and do not assume individual members of the initiatives studied are intentionally acting in malice. Instead, I focus on how affective politics operate in the data, using emotional and affective language as anchor points to inform broader conclusions. It is essential to recognize how inequality is un/intentionally and systemically

---

[62] Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor, "Preservation and Management Plan," 2006, accessed February 13, 2023, https://eriecanalway.org/resources/preserve–plan.

[63] Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor, "Preservation and Management Plan," New York State, "Reimagine the Canals Initiative," 2020, https://www.ny.gov/programs/reimagine–canals–initiative.

[64] Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor, "Preservation and Management Plan."

[65] Tuuli Lähdesmäki, "Politics of Affect in the EU Heritage Policy Discourse: An Analysis of Promotional Videos of Sites Awarded with the European Heritage Label," *International Journal of Heritage Studies* 23, no. 8 (2017): 712.

[66] Ahmed, "Affective Economies."

[67] Lähdesmäki, "Politics of Affect in the EU Heritage Policy Discourse," 712.

[68] Ahmed, "Affective Economies," Alexandre Emboabo Da Costa, "The (Un)Happy Objects of Affective Community: Mixture, Conviviality and Racial Democracy in Brazil," *Cultural Studies* 30, no. 1 (2016): 24–46, https://doi.org/10.1080/09502386.2014.899608; Tolia–Kelly, "Affect;" Tolia–Kelly, "Race and Affect at the Museum; "Tolia-Kelly, "Feeling and Being at the (Postcolonial) Museum."

[69] Lähdesmäki, "Politics of Affect in the EU Heritage Policy Discourse."

perpetuated through affect and emotion, because this can differentially shape capacities to resist state–sanctioned violence.[70]

The "Engineering Marvel" section, which encompasses the predominant affective politics and engineered subjectivities identified in the analysis, follows and addresses the first and second research questions. The concluding section considers the third research question, offering suggestions for resisting the affective politics of the Erie Canal promoted by NYS in the time period immediately preceding the 2025 bicentennial.

"Engineering Marvel"

The dominant affective politics and engineered subjectivities in this section are paired with aspects of Erie Canal heritage that are repressed to make what New York State renders absent present.

Enjoying and Celebrating (Genocide)

Enjoyment and celebration are central to the affective politics utilized by New York State in Erie Canal heritage marketing: "The stated mission of the Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor Commission is to plan for, encourage, and assist historic preservation, conservation, recreation, interpretation, tourism and community development throughout the Corridor in a manner that promotes partnerships among the Corridor's many stakeholders, and reflects, celebrates and enhances the Corridor's national significance for all to use and enjoy."

"The national significance of the canals will serve as a kind of melody line, while individual local and regional stories will provide vital harmonies and counterpoint."[71] In focusing on national significance, however, planning documents downplay Indigenous erasures and uphold tropes of *terra nullis*:

Waterways have played a prominent role in societies throughout time; indeed, the industries they fostered and the trade they facilitated form a large part of the story of civilization. Across the United States, vestiges of late nineteenth- and early twentieth–century canals, waterside factories, and mills pay homage to the Industrial Revolution that *transformed a largely unpopulated and unheralded place into a global superpower*. No example of this rich history is more recognized than the man–made Erie Canal, a symbol of the ingenuity, determination, and political will that made our nation (emphasis added).[72]

The interpretive framework situates American identity as the core theme.

"The interpretive challenge is to help visitors understand how what happened before the construction of the first canals in the 1790s relates to the central theme of the Corridor: the canal system and its role in shaping America." Listed as the first subtheme within the overarching "umbrella" is "Progress and Power – the canals as an expression of political will and economic power, and the dislocation of Native American societies." As an example, the plan suggests Rome, NY, "…where the first coordinated strike by Revolutionary Troops against Native American settlements originated." Thus, the interpretive framework largely

[70] Antonsich et al., "The Spaces and Politics of Affective Nationalism."

[71] What follows is a close reading of the following document: New York State Department of Transportation, *FINAL DESIGN REPORT / ENVIRONMENTAL ASSESSMENT* (2015), https://www.dot.ny.gov/main/business-center/designbuildproject46/repository/439013_rpt_fdr-ea_Approved%2010-21-2015.pdf.

[72] New York State Department of Transportation, *FINAL DESIGN REPORT / ENVIRONMENTAL ASSESSMENT*.

downplays the genocide and other violence inflicted on Haudenosaunee peoples, justifying the illegal theft of Indigenous lands as essential for the making of the American nation:

The construction of the Erie Canal and its laterals encompassed much of what we now consider to be fundamentally American: charismatic leadership, boldness and risk–taking, territorial expansionism, technological prowess, economic and industrial power, and social interchange. At the same time, the canals brought abuses –the dispossession and forced acculturation of Native Americans, the exploitation of immigrant labor– that Americans have since sought to mend. The Erie Canal served as the loom on which these separate threads were woven into a truly American fabric.[73]

Nevertheless, these abuses have not been mended. Affective politics help to disguise how the violent histories of the Canal continue to linger: "From an interpretive, educational, and orientation perspective, the overarching goal of the Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor is to enable a vibrant, engaging, dynamic, and satisfying user experience across the entire length of the Corridor. Future visitors to the region should encounter evidence of this effort *at every turn*" (emphasis added). Moreover, signage is "strategically placed" to "foster recognition, awareness, pride, and support among both residents and visitors." Within the graphic identity concept for the Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor (ECNHC), affective controls are straightforward:

The wordmark uses the words "Erie Canalway" with descending baselines for "Erie," "Canal," and "way" to visually allude to the lock system. The graphic use of strong, inviting letterforms to illustrate the motion of a boat passing through changing water levels is intended to be both legible and memorable…A mental pause is created when reading the wordmark, inviting reflection on its significance and connotations. [74]

Affective controls are tied to interpretation in terms of interconnection and awareness as well. Planning materials further outline that "[t]he concept of interconnection that formed the very core of DeWitt Clinton's original vision for the Erie Canal provides a versatile model for developing Corridor–wide interpretation and orientation." Such interpretive orientation is essential, because "Too few people today, including some Corridor residents, are fully aware of the region's rich history and extraordinary impact on the American identity."[75] Importantly, awareness should be cultivated at an early age. New York State's K–12 educational curricula "designed to increase awareness of the Corridor and appreciation of its resources among this significant audience group" are suggested. Awareness is therefore a basis for forming connections both physically and emotionally:

> The Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor exists to support and extend…existing momentum and harness this movement's energy to revitalize the region's public image and reinstate the Erie Canal and the New York State Canal System to their rightful place as American icons. As a national initiative, the Corridor is uniquely positioned to reestablish the *vital sense of physical and conceptual connectivity* that the Erie Canal once

[73] New York State Department of Transportation, *FINAL DESIGN REPORT / ENVIRONMENTAL ASSESSMENT*.

[74] New York State Department of Transportation, *FINAL DESIGN REPORT / ENVIRONMENTAL ASSESSMENT*.

[75] "Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor: Preservation and Management Plan," 2006, https://eriecanalway.org/resources/preserve-plan.

> provided between the nation's Atlantic Coast and its Midwestern heartland, and among the communities along the canal system's routes (emphasis added).[76]

Nevertheless, the violence inseparable from DeWitt Clinton's vision of interconnection is repeatedly ignored. The use of an arrowhead in the National Park Service banner also symbolizes ignorance of ongoing violence. Much like the forced relocations of Indigenous peoples to reservations, "The arrowhead resides where it is most effective, isolated from other words or symbols."[77] On the National Park Service website, the history of the arrowhead is stated to represent the historical and archaeological aspects of public lands and to relegate Indigenous peoples to the past symbolically.

However, "Adapting the Canal for the next century does not mean walking away from its past….New York has always been a national leader in progressive and creative thinking: successfully ushering in the 'third coming' of the iconic Erie Canal will provide a global example of how the past can once again be put towards the service of the future." At the same time, the Canal Commission ensures it will continue to "be informed by continued consultation with the region's Native American nations", admitting what is largely denied elsewhere–that Haudenosaunee peoples survived and maintained their sovereignty.

The Erie Canal's past cannot be separated from its violent legacy. Planning documents further refer to the Erie Canal as "a physical and conceptual spine," highlighting how violence manifests on the land and in bodies. While "some of [the] questionable ethics and legality" of this past are briefly referenced, these documents essentially repress the violent and traumatic aspects of Erie Canal heritage, instead opting for a celebratory politics of enjoyment:

Celebrating the prosperity attributable to the canal – the economic renaissance, expanded markets, the effective reduction in distance and time enjoyed by businesses, tourists, and settlers – means celebrating the nation's earliest regionally organized economic system. This system thrived because community and commercial self–interest overlapped with the common interest: towns and businesses alike owed their living to the canal.[78]

However, this life was made possible at the expense of others. An affective politics of enjoyment and celebration cannot be reconciled with genocide.

Investing and Expanding (Colonial Violence)

"Positioning the Corridor economy developingxpansion means… developing a broader regional consciousness," and affective politics are central to the economic development and expansion of the Erie Canal.

"Stretching from Albany to Buffalo, perhaps no single piece of infrastructure is more responsible for New York's rise as a state, and New York City's rise as a global capital, than the storied Erie Canal." The Reimagine the Canals Task Force Report "lays out a bold and inspiring vision that builds on the Canal System's legacy by leveraging and adaptively reusing its unique ability to control one of our State's most precious resources – its water." Planning documents refer to the "Corridor's relevance as a river of commerce and culture" and highlight affective movements in ways that mirror water: "Ripples of influence extend across

[76] "Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor: Preservation and Management Plan."
[77] "Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor: Preservation and Management Plan."
[78] "Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor :Preservation and Management Plan."

the length of the canals themselves and beyond, linking the region and the state to the world." The state "aim[s] to capitalize on [this] momentum" through tourism.[79]

"Tourism development planners must consider what creates a critical mass of attractions or a powerful enough 'experience magnet' to generate visitation in volume sufficient to create economic impact." To establish the "experience magnet", information control is crucial:

Visitor information is a vital part of the visitor service infrastructure and a key to establishing and maintaining both *physical and conceptual linkages* between Corridor sites and communities. Corridor support for visitor travel planning must be customer–driven and user-friendly, maximize the use of research and technology to *intercept visitors and potential visitors at key moments in the decision-making process,* and provide encouraging and straightforward mechanisms for purchasing Corridor travel products…[including] when the visitor returns home (emphasis added).[80]

Visitors are targeted geographically, demographically, and *psychographically*, with particular emphasis placed on "high value customers", highlighting the effective economies of these initiatives: "A marketing image is intangible yet must be compelling enough to *psychologically* and *emotionally* motivate people to spend the time and resources to travel. It must be carefully designed to reflect reality, to provide a unique positioning relative to competitor destinations, and to stimulate desire to visit (emphasis added)."[81]

Given the Corridor's size and diversity, its marketing image cannot be too specific or merely descriptive; it must be *emotionally resonant* with people today. It must also support a variety of complementary uses beyond tourism marketing, including direct efforts to boost economic development and residents' self–identification with local heritage. The Erie Canal is an American icon, a national treasure, and a "must–do" experience for heritage and recreation. It changed America and changed the way Americans see themselves. A visit to the Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor will change the visitor's perspective (emphasis added).[82]

Of the marketing image, planning materials further assert that it "does not just work for advertising; it is the *core element* of the National Heritage Corridor's mission" (emphasis added). "Economic activities that reinforce the market's sense of the National Heritage Corridor and strengthen its brand identity are especially valuable." [83]

"More than a triumph of engineering and construction, more than an engine of development and prosperity, more than a monument to political will and power, the Erie Canal endures as an idea,"[84] and the following example demonstrates how marketing initiatives draw the emotionally resonant idea of the Canal together with a tourism economy:

[T]he canal system is not just a historic or recreational resource; commercial shipping is crucial to the canals' ongoing role in the regional economy…. According to the New York State Canal Corporation, an estimated $102 million in cargo was transported via the canal system in 2004.

---

[79] New York (state), *REIMAGINE THE CANALS TASK FORCE REPORT* (2020), https://edge.sitecorecloud.io/newyorkpowe2bd0-canalsf418-productionbf60-c829/media/Files/Technical-Reports/TaskForceReport.pdf.

[80] "Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor: Preservation and Management Plan."

[81] Ibid.

[82] Ibid.

[83] Ibid.

[84] Ibid.

Watching a tug and barge maneuver through the canal, perhaps delivering cargo as impressive as a 300–ton generator bound for a midwestern power plant, makes for a memorable and informative experience. With proper interpretation, such an experience attracts residents and tourists to the waterfront. Also, it leads to greater support for commercial shipping in general, an underappreciated element of the nation's economic infrastructure.[85]

Thus, tourism is placed in concert with non–tourism economic benefits of the canal waterway, which include not only commercial shipping but also industries, research and development, agricultural activities, hydroelectric facilities, quarries and mining, public water supply for municipal water systems, waste-to-energy facilities, and golf courses. It is "important for each resource to provide a 'gateway' to the larger story of the Corridor, encouraging visits to other sites of interest and generating an understanding of the Corridor as a veritable treasure trove of history and culture."[86] At present, non–tourism benefits total an estimated $6.2 billion in annual economic impact. In comparison, tourism totals $1.3 billion, and tourism marketing effectively reinforces inadvertent support for these less publicized uses of the canal:

> A successful brand represents the totality of thoughts, emotions, reactions, and assumptions evoked by a product. Brand strategies differentiate places in the minds of consumers – visitors, shoppers, and people making business and residential location decisions – and create a sustainable competitive advantage. *The Erie Canal's widespread recognition and nostalgic affection are tremendously valuable assets requiring strategic deployment and a plan for protection. How can this resource be capitalized upon for economic advantage?*... The Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor will build an identity that *capitalizes on people's affection for canals in general (and the Erie Canal in particular*) (emphasis added).[87]

Investing in the Erie Canal is, therefore, an investment in the expansion of colonial violence in the form of neuropolitical power over the emotional and psychological responses of those engaging with it. Subsequently, feelings of marvel are engineered in fundamentally racialized ways, coercing visitors into subjectivities that maintain systems of racial capitalism predominantly at the expense of Haudenosaunee peoples and their traditional lands.

Towards resisting the affective politics of Erie Canal heritage

"Without a serious level of scrutiny and interrogation of abetting systems can institutions adequately grapple with the reproduction of historic inequalities that inform the public disaffection and lack of faith and trust in institutions that create a mass 'checking out' we cannot afford as a species."[88] My essay illustrates how such "disaffection" and "a mass checking out" to the Erie Canal's violent heritage are engineered and sanctioned by New York State in ongoing planning initiatives around the reimagining of the canal through tropes of American identity, *terra nullis*, economic progress, and global power, thus mirroring fundamental discourses in the DoCD. It demonstrates that the tourist–recreationist–consumer subjectivities sanctioned by New York State are those of celebration, joy, nostalgia, and affection for the Erie Canal, and anything that makes the state appear negatively is rendered

[85] Ibid.
[86] Ibid.
[87] "Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor: Preservation and Management Plan."
[88] Barry and Teron, "Visualizing Heritage," 11.

absent. As Lowenthal asserts, "Marketing corrupts its purveyors along with the heritage", and Erie Canal marketing reflects such corruption.[89]

In glossing over the violence of the Erie Canal, this corruption has neuropolitical consequences, rippling into the unconscious parts of our being, and can be understood as state–sanctioned racialized emotional and psychological abuse. Many Indigenous peoples and others who experience negative emotions, trauma, and do not resonate with the feelings of marvel for the canal engineered by the state might be cast as "affect aliens", thus revealing embodied environmental injustices that prevent healing.[90] At the same time, embodied defense mechanisms related to neuropolitical state controls may prevent (white) settlers from engaging with the violent realities of the Erie Canal, as these realities can shatter affective understandings grounded in feelings of marvel and pride, thereby perpetuating denials of historical truths that preclude possibilities for healing.

I therefore share Pulido et al.'s stance that the state should not be seen as an ally in addressing environmental injustices, but as an adversary.[91] In the context of the Erie Canal, change must go beyond expanding the narrative, diversifying exhibits, and including more people of color in tourism and recreation. Furthermore, it cannot be confined strictly to academic literature (including this paper). It should not be led by universities that continue to benefit from ongoing complicities in violent colonial and capitalist structures.[92] Justice must center the return of Indigenous lands through sovereignty and self–determination. Settlers should consider the intersecting ways in which we can contribute to unsettling, rematriation, and liberation in our different contexts, such as through the cultivation of reciprocal relations with Indigenous communities and disinvestment in colonial institutions and systems of racial capitalism, while remaining attentive to uneven complicities in unequally benefiting from and upholding systems of violence. In part, this requires a deeper embodied awareness of how denials of challenging the dominant Erie Canal narrative manifest, so that the affective politics of New York State can be resisted.

Fundamentally, this also requires a shift from pain- and damage–centered research to work rooted in desire–based frameworks of resistance, healing, thriving, and survival that engage nonlinearly with the past, present, and future.[93] Tuscarora scholar Alyssa Mt. Pleasant's work on Haudenosaunee placemaking at Buffalo Creek in the decades following the Revolutionary War and Sullivan–Clinton Genocide can serve as a guiding example: "Haudenosaunee people maintained their community at Buffalo Creek. The new settlement, then reservation, was home to hundreds of people determined to maintain their distinctive relationships with the land and with each other."[94] This determination continues today. In various videos recently posted to YouTube, Haudenosaunee people share their perspectives on the Erie Canal, noting desires for

---

[89] Burd, "A New, Historic Canal;" David Lowenthal, *The Heritage Crusade and the Spoils of History* (Cambridge University Press, 1998), 122.

[90] Da Costa, "The (Un)Happy Objects of Affective Community." Jane Palmer, Angelia Walsh, and Beata Batorowicz, "Parallel Futures? Indigenous Resurgence and the Haunting of the Settler," *Futures* 141 (2022): 1–12.

[91] Laura Pulido, Ellen Kohl, and Nicole–Marie Cotton, "State Regulation and Environmental Justice: The Need for Strategy Reassessment," *Capitalism Nature Socialism* 27, no. 2 (2016): 12–31.

[92] Sharon Stein, Unsettling the University: Confronting the Colonial Foundations of US Higher Education (Johns Hopkins University Press, 2022).

[93] Tuck, "Suspending Damage;" Eve Tuck and K. Wayne Yang, "R–Words: Refusing Research," in *Humanizing Research: Decolonizing Qualitative Inquiry with Youth and Communities,* ed. Django Paris and Maisha T. Winn (SAGE Publications, 2014).

[94] Mt. Pleasant, *After the Whirlwind*, 177.

truth and reconciliation as well as the return of illegally stolen lands, highlighting their survival, and emphasizing how they continue to uphold the various treaties the U.S. and settlers actively violate (Indigenous Values Initiative 2021; Tlaloc 2021a; 2021b).[95] Jake Edwards of the Onondaga Nation refers to the Erie Canal as a dam across Haudenosaunee homelands that disrupted their sacred relationships with water, reminding viewers that the waters of the land and our bodies are the same (Indigenous Values Initiative 2021).[96] Given the use of affective politics in Erie Canal heritage marketing that mirrors water, this dam may serve as a metaphor for the repressed emotions and embodied traumas created in relation to the canal's construction and New York State's ongoing marketing initiatives.

Challenges to achieving healing through Indigenous sovereignty should not be underestimated. As recently as 2005, in an opinion written by Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg, the Supreme Court of the United States upheld the DoCD. In the ruling for *City of Sherrill vs. Oneida Indian Nation of New York*, Ginsburg argued the Oneida Nation had let too much time pass to claim their sovereign rights while ignoring prior legal preclusions to doing so before 1974. Justice Antonin Scalia claimed monetary reparations could be possible. Still, he denied any possibilities for Oneida sovereignty, which he asserted would be too "chaotic" for U.S. citizens, disregarding the chaos of settler colonialism for Indigenous peoples. According to the ruling, the Oneida Nation could not exercise its sovereignty outside U.S. frameworks of private property, which are fundamentally misaligned with traditional Haudenosaunee practices, exemplifying federal denial of the legitimacy of treaties established with the Six Nations and the U.S., in addition to the fraudulent nature of treaties between the Haudenosanuee and NYS following the Federal Indian Trade and Intercourse Acts.[97]

Challenges around systemic denials are mirrored at the individual level. While scholars have highlighted the violent histories of public lands in the U.S., tourists and recreationists largely remain unable to critically and actively engage with historical truths and the issues they continue to perpetuate through ideologies of discovery and conquest.[98] However, recreation is complicit, not innocent, in colonial structures. Recreation and tourism emerged as technologies of colonial states and are embedded in the military occupation of stolen lands.[99] Researchers have speculated on how neurochemicals may contribute to embodied resistances and consumptive compulsions, and given how exercise contributes to neurochemical regulation in bodies, the use of affective politics by states in concert with recreation, heritage tourism, and marketing raises questions regarding how certain historical narratives become

---

[95] Indigenous Values Initiative, *Sacred Waters;* Fileve Tlaloc, *Haudenosaunee Perspectives: Erie Canal*, YouTube video, 6:53, November 16, 2021a, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_tahO7M6kCc; Fileve Tlaloc, *Haudenosaunee Perspectives: Erie Canal,* YouTube video, 4:44, November 16, 2021b, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IVI8bW1rxbw&t=2s.

[96] Indigenous Values Initiative, *Sacred Waters.*

[97] Palmer, "Rendering Settler Sovereign Landscapes."

[98] Janae Davis, "Black Faces, Black Spaces: Rethinking African American Underrepresentation in Wildland Spaces and Outdoor Recreation," *Environment and Planning E: Nature and Space* 2, no. 1 (2019): 89–109; Finney, *Black Faces, White Spaces;* Karl Jacoby, "Class and Environmental History: Lessons from 'The War in the Adirondacks,'" *Environmental History* 2, no. 3 (1997): 324–342; Antoinette T. Jackson, "Remembering Jim Crow, Again – Critical Representations of African American Experiences of Travel and Leisure at U.S. National Park Sites," *International Journal of Heritage Studies 25*, no. 7 (2018): 671–688; Rasul A. Mowatt, "A People's History of Leisure Studies: The Great Race and the National Parks and U.S. Forests," *Journal of Park and Recreation Administration 38*, no. 3 (2020): 152–172; Taylor, *The Rise of the American Conservation Movement;* T'shari L. White, "The Whitewashing of Wilderness: How History and Symbolic Annihilation Influence Black Americans' Perceptions of National Parks" (master's thesis, State University of New York, 2018).

[99] Taylor, *The Rise of the American Conservation Movement;* Hōkūlani K. Aikau and Vernadette Vicuña Gonzalez, *Detours: A Decolonial Guide to Hawai'i* (Duke University Press, 2019).

neurobiologically imprinted and embodied.[100] Future research could examine the intersections among fields such as heritage tourism, recreation, marketing, consumption, social change, psychology, and neurobiology to examine the consequences of erasing historical truths and how state–sanctioned, emotionally and psychologically abusive technologies of social control persist and can be contested. Such transdisciplinary work holds much potential for helping us better understand and address the complexities of (in)justice and contestations over lands and bodies, as seen in this study of the Erie Canal.

While this essay touched on issues underlying Erie Canal heritage with respect to Haudenosaunee peoples, others that were beyond the scope of this paper also continue to be actively erased, including racial redlining in major cities along the canal and abuses enacted towards human and more–than–human laborers.[101] "The erasure of discriminatory actions in planning history substantially influences the cultural history, context, and stories about places from which we seek inspiration, which we embed in the designs we generate."[102] To more holistically engage with and address such erasures, we can turn to Black, Indigenous, and communities of color more broadly, who have survived and thrived amidst centuries of systemic violence.[103] Khan proposes a mathematics for multispecies flourishing to counter colonial and capitalist logics of accumulation that arose from plantation economies.[104] Within heritage spaces, "[t]o disturb [dominant] frameworks requires a reflection on the self–perpetuating tactics of cultures of expertise, evidence, and on notions of what counts as 'knowledge.'"[105] Frameworks of connection and epistemologies of coordination that engage the depth of the robust literature by Black and Indigenous scholars can refocus research on relational resistance and survival in ways that exceed violent systems.[106]

Finally, this paper should not function as an act of white virtue–signaling or display of settler innocence, nor should it be weaponized to justify settler ignorance and denial. Instead, may it serve as an invitation for settlers to more critically reflect on how their own lives are tied to the Doctrine of Christian Discovery and the Erie Canal's role in making New York the "Empire State" and the U.S. a global empire. Tuck and Yang suggest that "[d]esire invites the ghosts that history wants exorcized and compels us to imagine the possible in what was written as impossible" (Tuck and Yang 2014, 235).[107] Water seeks to flow freely beyond a linear path, consistently exceeding the locks, dams, and other engineered structures on the Erie Canal that control it. Perhaps this is a lesson the canal offers today, reminding us that the state's "ripples of influence" can be interrupted; that dams can be cracked and fractured. By acknowledging the sacred relationships Haudenosaunee peoples hold with water, and by centering

---

[100] Machado de Oliveira, *Hospicing Modernity.*

[101] Barry and Teron, "Visualizing Heritage;" Michael T. Kelly, "Land Speculation and Suburban Covenants: Racial Capitalism and the Pre–Redlining Roots of Housing Segregation in Syracuse, New York," *Antipode 54,* no. 5 (2022): 1629–1649.; Sheriff, "'Not the True Centennial.'"

[102] Jennifer Low, "Design Is Political: White Supremacy and Landscape Urbanism," *Agora Journal of Urban Planning and Design* (2019): 130.

[103] Tuck, "Suspending Damage."

[104] Steven Khan, "After the M in STEM: Towards Multispecies' Flourishing," *Canadian Journal of Science, Mathematics and Technology Education* 20 (2020): 230–245.

[105] Tolia–Kelly, "Feeling and Being at the (Postcolonial) Museum," 907.

[106] McKittrick, "On Plantations, Prisons, and a Black Sense of Place;" Kyle Whyte, "Against Crisis Epistemology," in *Handbook of Critical Indigenous Studies*, ed. Aileen Moreton-Robinson, Lynda Tuhiwai Smith, Chris Anderson, Brendan Hokowhitu, and Steve Larkin (Routledge, 2021).; See also Zoe Todd, "An Indigenous Feminist's Take On The Ontological Turn: 'Ontology' Is Just Another Word For Colonialism," *Journal of Historical Sociology* 29, no. 1 (2016): 4–22.

[107] Tuck and Yang, "R–Words: Refusing Research," 235.

Haudenosaunee self–determination and sovereignty through peace and friendship, as the original treaties intended, we may find a multitude of possibilities beyond those sanctioned by New York State for truly radical re/imaginings of the Erie Canal.